employees get varies widely. The best way to learn about your plan is to read the information your employer provides, whether it’s online or in the handouts you got when you were hired. (I know, I know—this is about as much fun as doing your taxes. But the time you spend will be worth it.) Then make an appointment with whoever is in charge of benefits at your company so you can ask questions about your coverage.

In the health, disability, and life insurance sections below, I’ve listed specific steps that will help you evaluate your employer’s offerings. Meanwhile, here are some general rules to keep in mind:

- **If your company has a “flexible benefits plan,” make the most of it.** A flexible benefits plan (also known as a **flex plan** or a **cafeteria plan**) is a program that gives employees the opportunity to choose among a variety of benefits. Options often include health insurance, life insurance, and disability insurance. With some flex plans you may also be given a choice of noninsurance benefits, such as paid time off, legal services, or additional employer contributions to a 401(k) plan.
  Under a flex plan the employer gives you a fixed number of “credits” to spend on benefits. You get to decide how to use the credits. For instance, you may opt for a top-of-the-line health insurance plan but forgo life insurance, because, if you don’t have kids, you probably don’t need it yet. Or if your spouse has a terrific employer-sponsored health insurance plan that covers you, you could forgo your own company’s health insurance and opt for extra disability insurance. These plans can be extremely beneficial if you study your choices carefully and spend your credits wisely.